Does the Cart Reminder Email Pay Off?

Evaluation of the cart abandonment campaign, September to October 2026

Marketing Analytics Team

11 November 2026

1 Summary

The email vendor reports that 76.4% of customers who clicked the reminder email went on to buy. This number says little about the email itself, because customers who abandon a cart are already close to buying. In our randomized holdout, which received no email, 26.8% of customers placed an order within seven days anyway.

Compared with this holdout, the email raised the 7-day order rate by 2.5 pp (95% CI -0.8 pp to 5.8 pp, p = .146). The estimate is plausible and economically attractive, but the holdout was too small to distinguish it from zero. We therefore recommend continuing the campaign with a larger holdout.

2 Data and design

Between 1 September and 31 October 2026, 8,120 customers abandoned a cart and entered the campaign. A random 10% were assigned to a holdout that received no email. We excluded 499 customers whose 7-day outcome window extended beyond the data export, which leaves 7,621 customers (6,855 treatment, 766 holdout). The outcome is whether a customer placed an order within seven days after abandoning the cart.

3 What the vendor reports

Figure 1 compares the conversion rates that are typically reported. Clickers and openers are self-selected groups with high purchase intent, and the site-wide session conversion rate describes a different population. Only the comparison between all email recipients and the holdout isolates the effect of the email, because only the assignment to these groups was random.

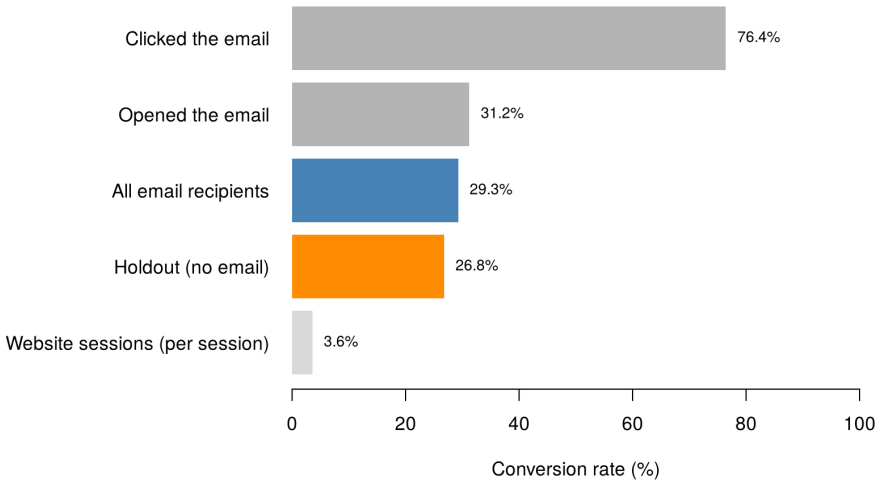


Figure 1: Conversion rates for different comparison groups. Only the blue and orange bars form a valid comparison.

4 Effect of the email

Table 1: Seven-day order rate by group (intention to treat).

Group	Customers	Orders	Order rate	Net revenue per customer
Holdout (no email)	766	205	26.8%	EUR 18.45
Treatment (email)	6,855	2,007	29.3%	EUR 19.97

Table 1 shows that 29.3% of the treatment group and 26.8% of the holdout ordered within seven days, a relative lift of 9.4%. Adjusting for cart value, device, customer tenure and loyalty tier gives nearly the same estimate (2.5 pp), which is expected under random assignment.

5 Economic value

Net of cancellations and returns, the email generated an estimated EUR 1.51 of additional revenue per treated customer, or EUR 10,375 in total (95% CI EUR -9,289 to EUR 30,040). Assuming a gross margin of 40% and campaign costs of EUR 614, the incremental profit is EUR 3,536.

The vendor attributes EUR 101,466 to the same campaign, about 10 times our estimate. The vendor counts every purchase within 30 days after an email was opened, including purchases that would have happened anyway, and it values each purchase at the abandoned cart value instead of the actual order value.

6 How large should the holdout be?

We simulated 10,000 experiments with our design, assuming a true lift of 2.5 pp on a baseline of 27%. Only 31% of them produced a significant result. Figure 2 shows a second problem with low power: the significant experiments overestimate the true effect, on average by a factor of 1.8.

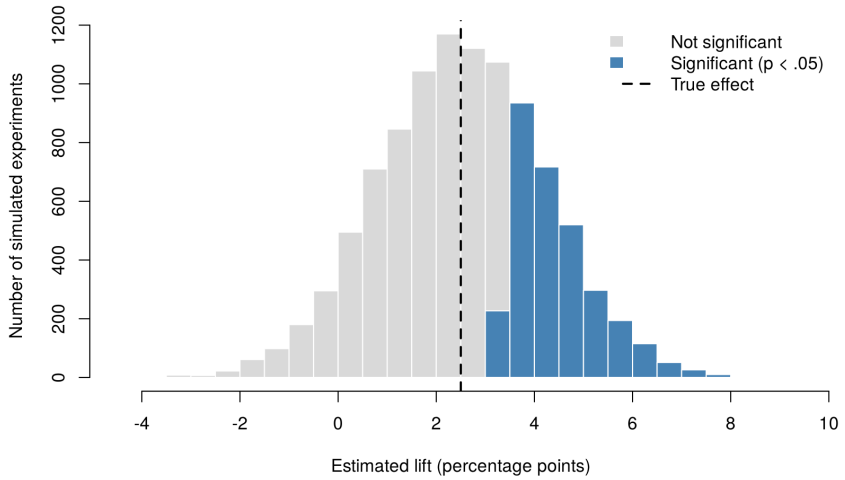


Figure 2: Estimated lifts in 10,000 simulated experiments with our design. Significant results (blue) overestimate the true effect (dashed line).

Figure 3 shows how power depends on the total sample and the holdout share. With a 10% holdout, about 30,000 enrolled customers are needed for 80% power. A 20% holdout reduces this to about 16,000, and a 50/50 split to about 12,000.

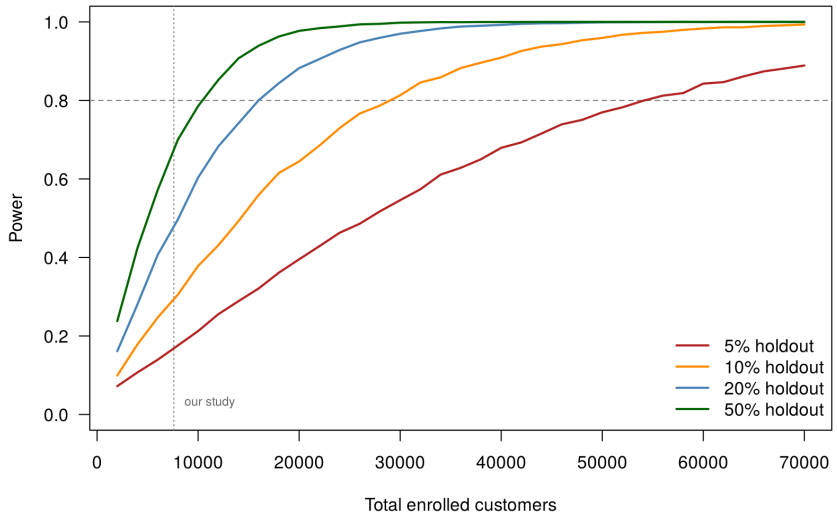


Figure 3: Simulated power to detect a 2.5 pp lift for different holdout shares. The dashed line marks 80% power.

7 Recommendation

We recommend continuing the reminder email, because the point estimate implies a positive return at low cost. At the same time, we recommend raising the holdout to 20% for the next 4 months, which would give the campaign enough data to confirm or reject an effect of this size. Vendor-reported conversion rates should not be used to evaluate the campaign.